

means talking about the circumstances under which it will be transferred. Few of us want to start a conversation with, 'Dad, when you die' ... or 'Mom, if you become unable to make decisions' ...

From the parents' point of view as well it is difficult to think about your own mortality, and the inter-generational transfer of assets is many times fraught with undercurrents of tension.

Will the child who supports me more stop the care if I divide assets equally? What if I want to leave all my things to the faith-based organization I belong to? Will this be an issue with the children?

For both sets of people across the generation divide, it may be easier to begin the conversation by either discussing the story of somebody else, who did or did not put affairs in order before moving on, or getting a trusted family friend to help initiate it.

Beyond the basic registered will document, the conversation needs to move on to end-of-life choices. A friend's mother was sure she did not want to look into the eyes of the ventilator when she breathed her last. That choice was respected when the time came.

It is important for you to have that conversation. If the topic is fraught with landmines of emotion, guilt and past family baggage, involve a trusted family friend or a financial planner. I've noticed that the people who are working with planners are able to deal with this much better than those without. (I've sourced parts of this piece from a column I wrote for *Mint* in August 2013.)

Complete your money box with a will in the final cell of the box. Hope that it is opened only after you die of old age and not before.

Life is fragile. Life is tenacious. We really don't know if the next day will come or not. Unclaimed investments and life insurance money run into thousands of crores. **You are doing OK if ...**

I. you have a valid will in place no matter what your age and stage (it's OK to have a will at age thirty-five);